

Army MARS Training Bulletin

7 June 2021

Mr. David McGinnis NETC HF Team
Ft Huachuca, AZ.

The purpose of this bulletin is to introduce two common Voice Message Templates that MARS Auxiliaries may encounter while supporting military training. They are, the Medical Evacuation (MEDEVAC) and SPOT Report (SPOTREP).

FM6-99

FM6-99 contains the joint message formats commonly used by the US Army. The MEDEVAC and SPOTREP are often exercised as these highlight basic infantry skills. Since COMEX 21-1, all Army MARS are expected to hold copy of FM6-99.

AMARS Support to Military Training:

MARS may be called upon from time to time to simulate the far end of a communications circuit for US military units that are training or exercising. This allows the military unit to practice and train tasks without having to coordinate other organizations that would normally receive and process tactical messages. Most tactical messages are sent by lines using voice procedure and are sometimes referred to generically as "9 Line" (although that term is specifically for the MEDEVAC message).

- 1) In most cases where MARS stations are simulating the far end communications circuit there is no requirement to relay or process the messages other than retain and submit to the unit by email at the conclusion of the training. Service members may be evaluated based on what they sent, and in that case specific instructions for submitting copy back to the evaluators will be provided. MARS stations shall always copy down all traffic on the frequency that is sent to them, or copied by intercept.
- 2) Collective Call Signs. In some cases to ensure the best possible radio circuit, the training will be structured so that multiple MARS stations will be standing by to receive traffic from the unit that is training. It is likely the unit will not know the call sign of each MARS station; rather, they will use a collective call sign that MARS stations will answer. FIRESTAR is the normal collective call sign for all MARS stations, although in some cases other collective call signs that are unique to the tactical message type or unit that is training may be employed. The technique that MARS stations will use to answer a collective call is as follows:
 - a. Each MARS station will note the signal strength they received from the calling station. MARS stations that receive the calling station Loud and Clear will answer quickly. MARS stations that receive the calling station weakly will wait for stations with better reception to answer first and only respond if a stronger station does not. The MARS station will answer the call to the collective call sign using their individual MARS call sign in abbreviated format followed by the signal report. The answer will be concise, verbalized quickly without extra verbalizations or the traditional "This Is" pause.
For instance: COYOTE ALPHA THIS IS NINER ROMEO ECHO, YOU ARE LOUD AND CLEAR, OVER.
 - b. The radio station from the unit training will most likely answer the loudest MARS station. Once communications is established with that station, all other MARS stations will stand by and continue to copy down all traffic on the channel by intercept.

- 3) The MARS station that is selected to receive the traffic will say "SEND IT" after the preliminary call is complete and they are ready to receive the message. The sending station may send the traffic using a variety of techniques that may include, sending the entire message at once, breaking momentarily after each line before moving on, or line by line expecting read-back on each line. The question HOW COPY? solicits a read-back – Say I COPY followed by the read-back. In all cases, messages are always read back to the sending station using one of these techniques.
- 4) Radio equipment on VHF, TACSAT and HF using digital voice is now ubiquitous in the US military and most personnel are taught to speak very softly into the microphone to avoid distortion. This technique is antithetical to good SSB operation; and you may have to request they speak up.
- 5) Note that traditional radio telephone procedure is greatly simplified and different than MARS. The full lexicon of pro-words are rarely used or trained and unofficial pro-words are common – get used to it.
- 6) The service member operating the radio may have a tendency to speak too fast. If they are going faster than what is demonstrated in the video examples here:
<http://www.usarmymars.org/training/skill-level-1-basic-training>
you may ask them to slow down. You may also ask them to go line by line.
- 7) DUSTOFF is commonly used as a collective call sign with the MEDEVAC message. DUSTOFF is the collective call sign for the MEDEVAC or CASEVAC helicopter, and the units training may want to exercise tasks using that call sign. MARS will reply to DUSTOFF only when it is specifically within their supporting role to receive MEDEVAC messages from military units that are training (IOW: when specifically authorized).

Notes

- 1) Tactical Messages are usually sent at a faster rate than MARS Auxiliarists are used to receiving. To support this training, MARS Auxiliarists must improve the speed at which they can receive voice traffic. This is analogous to improving speed copying Morse code. Videos of the messages presented here, verbalized at realistic speed are presented at <http://www.usarmymars.org/training/skill-level-1-basic-training>
- 2) Local site noise (Electro-Magnetic Interference EMI) is often the limiting factor for radio telephone communications. A signal to noise ratio of 6 to 12db is required for reliable reception of Single Side Band communications. While improvement of up to 17db is possible at the transmitting station, EMI at the receiver often accounts for up to 30db of signal loss due to the elevated noise floor. There are more significant gains to the overall circuit power budget by eliminating EMI to lower the noise floor at the receive site than by increasing power at the transmitting station.

Tasks to Trainers

- 1) Familiarize MARS Auxiliarists with the MEDEVAC and SPOTREP voice message templates.
- 2) Encourage Auxiliarists to practice and improve skill and speed receiving voice messages. Use the videos on usarmymars.org and live practice on nets. Present opportunities for Auxiliarists to practice and demonstrate proficiency in receiving tactical voice messages from FM6-99.
- 3) Identify Auxiliarists who consistently have difficulty receiving messages.